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Become a Growing Church

What is Your Motivation for Preaching?

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Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

What is Your Motivation for Preaching?

Why do you preach? Pastors step into the pulpit for many reasons:

- Institutional duty or the simple habit of filling the weekly preaching slot
- Enjoyment of public speaking or the desire for affirmation and recognition
- Pressure to grow attendance, giving, or outward measures of success
- Personal growth—the discipline of weekly preparation that keeps the pastor in the Word
- A desire to speak into cultural issues and bring clarity or courage to the moment
- Genuine love for Scripture and eagerness to share what has stirred their own heart
- Evangelistic burden for the lost who may be present
- Simple obedience to God’s calling to preach the Word faithfully, whether results are visible or not
- Deep love for the people and a desire to see believers grow and flourish in Christ

Some pastors preach primarily because it is their assigned responsibility. They may find satisfaction in public speaking or in the affirmation that follows a well-received message. In such cases, the underlying motive remains largely self-focused.

Other pastors approach the pulpit from a deeper place. Motivated by a genuine love for Scripture, they view the weekly preparation as a personal opportunity for spiritual growth. They trust that the truths the Lord has impressed upon their own hearts will, in turn, strengthen and instruct those who listen.

Still others are moved chiefly by concern for the spiritual condition of their people. Attuned to the needs the Holy Spirit reveals, they craft their messages to address the real struggles and longings of the congregation. Their greatest joy comes not from the act of preaching itself, but from witnessing lives transformed as believers grow in the likeness of Christ.

Your Motivation Will Determine the Message

A pastor’s deepest motivation quietly but powerfully shapes both the content and the tone of the sermon.

When the primary drive is personal—whether fulfilling a job requirement, enjoying the platform, or seeking affirmation—the message often leans toward what will be well-received. Difficult texts may be softened, challenging applications avoided, and the sermon crafted more for immediate approval than for lasting transformation. The focus tends to rest on the preacher’s performance rather than on the hearer’s encounter with God.

When the motivation rises to a genuine love for Scripture and personal growth, the sermon usually becomes richer in biblical content. The pastor speaks from truths that have first stirred his own heart. Yet even here the message can remain somewhat centered on what the preacher finds most compelling, rather than on what the congregation most urgently needs.

The highest motivation—concern for the spiritual condition of the people, guided by the Holy Spirit, and rooted in obedience to God’s call—produces a different kind of sermon. The text is still carefully handled, but the application is shaped by the real struggles, questions, and longings of the congregation. Hard truths are not avoided, yet they are delivered with pastoral care. The aim is not merely to inform or to impress, but to see lives changed as the Word, applied by the Spirit, forms Christ in the hearers.

In short, motivation determines whether the sermon serves the preacher, the text alone, or the people under the authority of the text. The purest motive consistently yields messages that are faithful to Scripture, sensitive to the Spirit’s leading, and aimed at the genuine growth of the people.

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Thank you again for partnering with us in the Great Commission. May the Lord continue to fill you with joy, peace, and purpose as you walk with Him.

In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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